



PSYCHOLOGY 30

ESTIMATED COST OF RAISING A CHILD FROM BIRTH TO ADULTHOOD

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Birth, the start of something very new to this world, the start of an individual with infinite possibilities and chances to leave a lasting change on this world. No one remembers how they were born, nor do they remember anything specifically from the incident, or the days afterwards. But for this child to come into this world, is a mother who bears a lot of pain, carrying the baby for months and the excruciating pain of child birth. At the cost of the mother's hard work, time and energy, a new child is born, not to demean the father's effort too, but a mother's role is definitely greater. But it is clear, that from the time the child is born, to the time this child becomes an independent adult, there are lots of sacrifices that parents have to make.

RAISING A BABY TO ADOLESCENCE

From the time this baby is born, a lot of efforts have to be made in order to ensure its proper growth. The baby starts develop new senses, recognizing its new abilities and learning more about its environment. The brains absorbs as much information it can, and helps the child develop. So for the next 5 years, this child will learn to speak, understand taste, listen and understand, start walking, and become more aware of their surroundings (1). Lots of changes begin to take place, but it doesn't happen all alone, the people around this child influence a lot of its behavior and the environment shapes a lot of the babies cognitive abilities. And this mainly comes down to the parents, who spend selflessly, within their capabilities to provide this child with enough food, all the toys they need and more, vacations and education. Over a shorter span, the expenses on a child may seem little, but over a longer span, these expenses might seem terrifying! But it is not only the financial expenses which matter, a parents time spent with the child, shapes a lot of their characteristics and behavior. Every little interaction, allows the child's mind to learn something new, every little bit of love, gives the child's mind an unknown comfort

(2). Now as the child grows even more, they start to become less dependent on the parent, and becomes less attached, however, the parents still have a very important role in the growth of the child. They start to learn a lot more from their environment, as the saying goes, "we learn what we see". The relationship between a parent and the child nurtures how the individuals characteristics grow. A good relationship ensures a better social life for the child as they are more confident, and have better social interactions. Children who are deprived of love from their parents, may suffer from anxiety and depression, and suffer from insecurities as they do not receive proper love and comfort at home, hence there is an emotional emptiness. Now obviously there is a lot of emotional support required, but for this child to grow, an astonishing amount of money has to be spent too. From food, education, clothing, entertainment, a child's growth from birth to adolescence requires a lot of financial backing. For a middle income family, it costs \$300000, to raise a child. But not all families are in the same financial situation. There are families with lower incomes and higher incomes. Higher income families spend upwards of \$400000 and lower income families spend around \$238000 (3). This cost is slightly reduced by the Government's child care program, for children under 18, and this reduces the cost by \$83000. But the question comes, does this spending really effect a child's growth?

FINANCE AND A CHILD'S GROWTH

There is a significant difference between a wealthy child and a poorer child's outcomes. Since they grow up in different environments, the opportunities and resources available to them are greatly different and this means, the knowledge and experiences they gain will be hugely different. According to statistics, children from poorer families have worse outcomes than those from wealthier families. A lack of resources, may result in

malnutrition as they don't get enough food hence they become physically weak. When the parents are in stress, they can't spend enough time with the children, hence they don't get enough love and support, so there is a lacking in emotional support. This can lead to anxiety and depression. Without proper education, children also turn to harmful ways, which can be bad for a community (4).

RAISING A TEENAGER

Once the child grows into a teenage, a lot of responsibilities ease up for the parents, but they are faced with more new challenges. As the child grows into a teenager, they want less support from their parents, in search of self identity and agency. During this time, an adolescent tries to become more independent and prepares to tackle the real world by themselves, hence their childish behaviors fade away. But the parents support is still important, because in the midst of the idea that they are self sufficient, and in a search of identity, they forget to take care of themselves (1). And even though they may look like they don't need their families, it is still the parent's money and shelter which nurtures them, as it becomes a one sided love affair, giving from the parents, and taking from the adolescent. But the parents still fuel them, in the hopes that one day, they won't have to anymore. In this big transition period, parents have to invest a lot of their finances again. From university tuition, more fashion interests in a challenge to fit in with their friends, and careless spending, the amount spent parents on these individuals rise by about 29% above the amount spent on them during their childhood (3). So it can be really expensive to raise a child into adulthood, with a lot of physical and mental effort. Besides the finance, the parents must still make effort to support their child. They are still not strong enough to face the challenges alone, nor their personal challenges. The parents must guide them to overcome their

difficulties, even when they show they don't want it.

Communication is very important for these adolescents, so they can feel comfortable enough to discuss solutions. A good relationship with their parents will also help them in their adulthood, where they are more comfortable to take on challenges and become happy and independent adults. It gives them resiliency to deal with more difficult times, and reduces the effects of traumatic experiences in their childhood. (5)

THE OUTCOME OF OVERSPENDING

The question then becomes, is all this spending worth it? Do these have a good outcome on the child? Well raising a kid is expensive and we know that poor conditions have adverse effects on a child. However, overspending and too much spending on children can make them spoilt. When they get whatever they want, everything becomes accessible to them without trying and their brains start to lose motivation to do anything, since they don't have to try to get something, it's as simple as asking. Hence, pleasures that reach them reduce their ability to adhere to pain and hard work. It makes it harder for the child to take on challenges, as from a young age, they were not familiar with taking on challenges. Sometimes, making them work hard on their school exams to get a new game instead of just giving it to them, goes a long way, in teaching them the fruits of hard work (6). It is important for parents to harness their children's mentality so their brains won't always try to find easy solutions to any problem.

CONCLUSION

Raising a child is not an easy task. Handling a child's tantrums and comforting them hard times is just as important as providing with healthy foods and a good education. Even as the child grows up and changes in every dimension, a parent must also adapt to their change and understand the child's needs. Sometimes it may not be easy for the parent, as raising any child is a unique experience

for the parents, but backing down isn't a choice, because they may be raising a future scientist, an engineer, doctor or maybe a physician. Providing the perfect conditions is what will help these children reach their potentials, and might as well become a good investment!

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